



### Printer

A good laser or inkjet printer will cost Rs 15,000 upwards



### Photocopier

A typical heavy-duty office copier can cost upwards of Rs 40,000

necessary buttons such as the fax dial pad, menu setup, scan, copy, etc. on the control panel. Samsung, on the other hand, sports a regular fax machine design, with the handset integrated. This means that it can be used as a telephone unlike the HP and Brother units.

### Fax

The Brother MFC-9660 can store only 32 speed-dial numbers, whereas Samsung stores a maximum of 90 speed-dial numbers with 10 speed dial hot keys. The HP offers 120 speed dial numbers, but with just seven hotkeys. The Brother MFD can store as much as 500 pages in its memory—the Samsung stores 160, and the HP only 110 pages. The MFC-9660 lets you send a fax broadcast to as many as 182 locations, whereas the HP only allows for a group dial function to a maximum of 120 entries. The Samsung, which is primarily a fax machine, only allows a hotkey entry (a two-digit entry), which translates to a total of 99 recipients. So, the HP and Brother actually offer better fax features than the Samsung!

### Printing

Both the HP and Brother have laser-based printers devices. Both printed at the claimed speed of 14 to 15 pages per minute (PPM). The Samsung, however, is primarily a fax machine, and thus prints at a slow 6 PPM. In our speed tests, the HP took the crown—taking just 11 seconds to print our test document. It also managed to yield crisp results—the Brother took twice the time to finish the same job. In our mixed document test (text, graphics and images), the HP managed to print the document in just 19 seconds. The Brother took 25 seconds for the same job.

Brother's huge 250 sheet capacity, dominates the 150 sheet capacity HP and Samsung. The Samsung MFD has a top loading paper tray, while both the HP and the Brother have the laser printer style, front-loading cassette. The Brother scores again over the others, because of its sliding paper cassette and manual-loading slot for envelopes, labels and transparencies.

### Scanning

Scanning is where the HP 3015 stands out. It's the

## The HP 3015 stands out when it comes to scanning, with a 600 dpi scan resolution, and a 24-bit colour depth

only MFD in this category with a 600 dpi scan resolution, and 24-bit colour depth. The test scans were decent—it picked up 19 out of 22 shades of grey, and also did well in the colour deviation test.

Brother scans in monochrome (256 shades of gray) at 600 dpi, which means you'll have to invest extra to buy an external colour scanner. Samsung can only scan at a quality acceptable for a fax machine. We did not run the scanning tests on the Brother and Samsung models.

Both HP and Brother scan documents at 100 dpi, by default. In order to scan at 600 dpi, you'll need to use

the 'scan to image' function and use your PC to import the image via the TWAIN driver.

Brother MFC-9660 has three hotkeys for Scan to e-mail, OCR and image. HP has a 'Scan to' button on the control panel that can be configured to Scan to e-mail, OCR, Folder, or other programs, using the software provided. This feature is handy, as you can set the scanner to quickly scan to whatever choice you use most often.

### Copy

HP claims to copy at 15 ppm, scanning at 600 dpi, but our tests showed that it copies at about 12 PPM—the first copy took 14 seconds. The Brother claims similar speeds, but only managed 10 PPM. You should keep in mind that these speeds will vary, depending on the contents of the documents you want to copy.

### Verdict for Personal MFDs

All three MFDs have their areas of strength, and weaknesses. HP has a small footprint, a better scanner and a faster printer and copier. Brother has 32 hotkeys for speed dial and offers a straight paper path option for printing envelopes, transparencies, etc. The Samsung offers a handset to make telephone calls without wasting extra money and space on a phone instrument. It is small, but priced too high at Rs 27,000—especially considering the below average feature set and slow printer module.

Brother offers the most features, but lags behind HP because of the monochrome scanner unit. Brother MFC-9660 is priced at Rs 31,400, beaten by HP's price of Rs 22,500. HP seems to be the obvious choice here.

### Workgroup MFDs

For a low to medium volume of printing and copying, MFDs based on laser printer engines are preferred. These are generally deployed as shared resources in departments.

A total of 10 MFDs fell into this category with three each from Brother and HP, two from Samsung and one each from Xerox and Canon. Almost all the vendors have a base model without fax as well as upscaled versions that have the same printer and scanner units with fax added on.

### Design

Brother MFDs sport an elegant and sober look that should go well with any office décor. The off-white body panels, large four-line backlit LCD and the subtle use of blue panels make it a



## Multi-Functional Devices - Buy / Do Not Buy

### Small footprint and cost-effectiveness

Instead of having to buy four or five different machines—and maintain each with different replacement toners, drums and other parts—you can purchase a single machine whose printing, scanning and copying functions use the same cartridge

**Network considerations** Adding one device to the network instead of four separate devices, with all the associated cabling and driver software is easier. Four devices is

four security problems and four service warranties, whereas one engineer can support an MFD

**Quality** An all-in-one machine may not offer the same high quality in each of its functions as separate machines

**Breakdowns** If one of the functions breaks down, the entire machine is unusable. To preclude such a disaster, several manufacturers offer warranties with 24-hour express replacement, on-site exchange or fast repairs